

1. What is a Water Licence Application?

Water licences and approvals allow people to divert, use or store surface water or groundwater, or to make changes in and about a stream.

Water licences and approvals are issued for water use purposes supporting agriculture, commerce, domestic household requirements (surface water only), habitat conservation, industry, natural resources development, power production, water storage and water supply.

The Province of British Columbia authorizes licences and approvals, and holders must comply with provincial, local and in some cases federal regulations.

2. What is a new water licence application supported here?

A New Water Licence Application in BC is a formal request submitted through FrontCounter BC to the provincial government for authorization to divert, use, or store surface water (streams, springs) or groundwater (wells). Required under the Water Sustainability Act, this process ensures water use is authorized, sustainable, and beneficial.

3. Are there any important things to be aware of from this water permit application perspective ?

If you only want to use the water for 24 months or less, please consider if the **Short-term use of water approval application** would meet your needs. Link , URL :

<https://j200.gov.bc.ca/pub/vfcbc/Default.aspx?PossePresentation=VFStartApplication&PosseObjectId=64727182>

If you wish to use **groundwater to support an oil and gas activity under the Oil and Gas Activities Act or the Petroleum and Natural Gas Act** contact the [BC Energy Regulator](https://www.bc-er.ca/). URL :

<https://www.bc-er.ca/>

4. What is the Water Sustainability Act?

The Water Sustainability Act (WSA) was brought into force on February 29, 2016 to ensure a sustainable supply of fresh, clean water that meets the needs of B.C. residents today and in the future.

The WSA is the principal law for managing the diversion and use of water resources. The WSA provides important new tools and updates B.C.'s strategy for protecting, managing and using water efficiently throughout the province.

URL : <https://www.bclaws.gov.bc.ca/civix/document/id/complete/statreg/14015#section2>

Entire Water Sustainability Act :

<https://www.bclaws.gov.bc.ca/civix/document/id/complete/statreg/14015>

5. What is '**Apply with BCeID**'?

Apply with BCeID in the water application means you sign in using your BCeID account before starting or continuing your application. When you apply with BCeID, you can save your progress and return later to complete the application if needed. This option helps prevent data loss because your information is stored securely, and you can use the Save Application feature multiple times before submitting. It is the recommended option for applicants who may not be able to finish the application in one session.

6. Can I apply without BCeID? Or What does it mean by '**Apply without BCeID**' ?

Yes, an Applicant can apply **without** BCeID. Applying without a BCeID means that if you leave your computer for a long time without submitting your application, all information you have entered will be lost. There is no way to stop and then continue later unless you sign in with a BCeID.

7. Do I need a BCeID Account to apply for a water permit application?

No. BCeID account is NOT mandatory for applying for a water license application. However, applying without a BCeID means that if you leave your computer for a long time without submitting your application, all information you have entered will be lost. There is no way to stop and then continue later unless you sign in with a BCeID.

8. What is BCeID?

The BCeID Identity and Authentication Service is managed by the Identity Services program in Service BC. The Service is available to people who are seeking secure and safe access to government services online without using a BC Services Card. More details about BCeID :

<https://www.bceid.ca/aboutbceid/>

The Service is available to people who require safe, public sector services online with an easy-to-use log-in system. It is a centralized and consistent way to verify the identity of an individual by providing:

- Individuals, businesses and organizations access to numerous government services online with an easy-to-use, secure, single sign-on credential
- Convenient user access that requires only a username and password
- Standard implementation of authentication and authorization policy
- Cost savings to government through economies of scale for IT infrastructure and expertise

9. What is Oil and Gas?

Oil and natural gas are produced when organic matter from millions of years ago is subjected to heat and pressure.

Ref: <https://www.bc-er.ca/what-we-regulate/#page-1>

10. What is the Petroleum and Natural Gas Act?

This is the government legislation that allows the Ministry of Energy and Climate Solutions to regulate the bidding process for sub-surface tenure rights and charge rents and royalties for the resources.

REF: <https://www.bc-er.ca/what-we-regulate/#:~:text=through%20the%20courts-,Petroleum%20and%20Natural%20Gas%20Act,and%20royalties%20for%20the%20resources.>

11. What is the BC Energy Regulator?

The BC Energy Regulator is a single-window regulatory agency with responsibilities for overseeing energy resource activity operations, refineries, and geothermal development in British Columbia.

12. What is a short-term water use or Short-term use of water approval or Short-term use of water approval application?

Short-term water use for energy projects is treated as a related activity, and the Regulator can issue approvals only if applicants meet the required criteria. For major projects, approvals may sometimes be granted before a primary activity permit exists. Applications can be submitted on their own or with a primary activity, but stand-alone applications must include a cross-reference to the related activity. For more details, applicants can contact the Major Projects team at the BC Energy Regulator.

Approvals are valid for up to 24 months and cannot be extended beyond that period. If water use is needed after 24 months, a new application must be submitted with references to the previous authorization. If activities have not started before expiry, a new approval is required.

13. What is human confirmation? Or Why is there a checkbox saying **I'm not a robot ?** or What is **Captcha code** ?

Human confirmation in an application, commonly known as human verification or bot detection, is a security mechanism designed to distinguish between real human users and automated scripts (bots). These mechanisms are crucial for preventing spam, account hijacking, fraudulent transactions, and data scraping.

Water Permit applications do have a Bot or Robot verification step to confirm that you are an actual human, this is required and can be done by validation of a *captcha*, and for proceeding with the permit application.

14. What is a robot ? or What is a bot ?

A robot is a programmable, autonomous, or semi-autonomous machine designed to sense its environment, process information, and execute physical actions or tasks with speed and precision. They replace human effort in dangerous, repetitive, or complex tasks, ranging from industrial arms to household vacuums, and are designed for functionality.

15. What is Eligibility to Apply?

You are eligible to apply for a water licence if you can answer “Yes” to at least one of the following situations. This includes being the **owner of land** or a mine in British Columbia where the water will be used, being entitled to possession of that land or mine, or having a substantial interest in the land, mine, or undertaking where the water will be used. You may also be eligible if you hold a certificate of public convenience and necessity issued under applicable utility legislation, or if you are a municipality, regional district, improvement district, development district, or water users’ community. Eligibility also applies if you are representing the Government of British Columbia or the Government of Canada, or a commission, board, or authority responsible for Crown land, a mine, or an undertaking administered or controlled by these governments. In addition, organizations such as the Greater Vancouver Water District or the British Columbia Hydro and Power Authority may apply. You may also be eligible if you are applying as an authorized agent on behalf of any eligible applicant described above.

16. What is a certificate of public convenience and necessity?

The water utilities application process requires a Certificate of Public Convenience and Necessity (CPCN), which is granted by the Comptroller of Water Rights under authority from the Water Sustainability Act and the Utilities Commission Act.

The B.C. government provides assistance in developing and delivering all of the necessary information required for the application process.

17. What is a Water Utility Act?

This Act applies only to water utilities that fall under the legislative authority of the Government of British Columbia. If a water utility provides certain types or classes of services that are not subject to British Columbia's legislative authority, this does not prevent the Act from applying to other services offered by the same utility that are within provincial jurisdiction. In other words, the Act continues to apply to any class of service that is regulated by British Columbia, even if other services provided by the utility are regulated elsewhere.

18. What is the water users' community?

A water users' community (WUC) is a group of six or more water licensees, each with their own licence(s), who create and maintain a system to store and deliver water to their respective places of use.

Water users' communities are incorporated and named by the Comptroller of Water Rights.

The Water Users' Communities Act: On February 29, 2016, most of the Water Act was repealed and replaced by the Water Sustainability Act. Part 3 of the Water Act became the Water Users' Communities Act, which governs the creation and management of water users' communities.

Purpose of a WUC: A WUC may acquire, hold and control property and water licences. The community may also acquire, construct, hold, maintain, improve, replace and operate works. WUC members may save money and time through sharing resources and works used to divert water.

A Memorandum of Agreement (DOC, 22KB) is signed by licence holders to form a WUC.